

Yuri Gagarin

Pre-Reading

A. Warm-Up Questions

1. Are you interested in space travel?
2. Have you ever heard of Yuri Gagarin?
If so, what do you know about him?
3. Do you know which country launched the first unmanned spacecraft?
4. Do you know which country launched the first manned spacecraft and when this took place?
5. Have you ever heard of the celebration called Yuri's Night?
6. What is a space shuttle?



B. Vocabulary Preview

Match up as many words and meanings as you can.

Check this exercise again after seeing the words in context on page 2.

- | | |
|-----------------------|---|
| _____ 1. orbit | a) a person who travels in space, an astronaut |
| _____ 2. launch | b) a huge hole in the ground |
| _____ 3. survive | c) something that transports people and things back and forth |
| _____ 4. cosmonaut | d) to continue to live |
| _____ 5. altitude | e) something done successfully with effort and skill |
| _____ 6. parachute | f) a path followed by one body around another |
| _____ 7. hero | g) to learn and practise something |
| _____ 8. commander | h) height |
| _____ 9. train | i) to send up, to start, to set in motion |
| _____ 10. crater | j) a person who is respected for being very brave |
| _____ 11. achievement | k) a leader, a person in charge |
| _____ 12. shuttle | l) to jump from a plane using an umbrella-shaped device |

Reading

1. Yuri Gagarin was the first person to **orbit** the earth in a spacecraft.
2. Gagarin was born in Klushino, a village near Moscow, Russia, on March 9, 1934. His parents worked on a Soviet collective farm. As a young man, he learned how to fly while he was training to be a foundry worker. In 1955, he joined the air force and became a fighter pilot instead.
3. Russia **launched** the world's first unmanned spacecraft, *Sputnik*, in 1957. In 1960, Gagarin was among 20 people who were tested to see if they could **survive** space travel. Gagarin did very well in the tests and was chosen to be the first **cosmonaut**.
4. On April 12, 1961, Gagarin was sent into space aboard *Vostok 1*. A computer controlled the flight because scientists were not sure how he would react in the weightlessness of space. The spacecraft circled the earth, travelling about 18,000 miles (about 28,968 kilometres) an hour at an **altitude** of almost 188 miles (about 302.5 kilometres). The flight lasted 108 minutes. Before the craft landed, Gagarin **parachuted** to earth, landing in Siberia.
5. After the flight, Gagarin was a Russian **hero**. The government sent him and his wife, Valya, on a world tour so that people everywhere would know about the success of its space programme.
6. Gagarin was made **commander** of the cosmonaut **training** programme and worked to prepare others to go on space flights. He trained the first woman to go into space, Valentina Tereshkova.
7. In 1967, he began to train for his second space flight. However, on March 27, 1968, he died when the jet he was flying crashed in bad weather. Gagarin's ashes were buried in the Kremlin wall beside other Soviet heroes.
8. A **crater** in the moon was named for Gagarin, and since 2001, a celebration called Yuri's Night is held every April 12 in many parts of the world. It celebrates his **achievement** as well as the first space **shuttle** launch on April 12, 1981.

*'I could have gone
on flying through
space forever.'*

—Yuri Gagarin

Comprehension

A. True or False?

Read the statements below.

If the statement is true, write T beside the sentence.

If it is false, write F and correct the information in your notebook.

- _____ 1. Yuri Gagarin was a member of the Russian air force.
- _____ 2. *Sputnik* was the world's first manned spacecraft.
- _____ 3. Gagarin landed in his spacecraft in Siberia.
- _____ 4. Gagarin became very famous throughout Russia.
- _____ 5. Gagarin made many space flights.

B. Ask & Answer

Practise asking and answering the following questions with your partner.

Then write your answers in complete sentences in your notebook.

- 1. Why did Yuri Gagarin become world-famous?
- 2. Why was Gagarin chosen to be Russia's first cosmonaut?
- 3. Describe Gagarin's flight aboard *Vostok 1*.
- 4. Why was the first manned space flight controlled by a computer?
- 5. Why did the Russian government send Gagarin and his wife on a world tour after his space flight?
- 6. What kind of work did Gagarin do after his space flight?
- 7. Why did Gagarin not make a second space flight?
- 8. What is Yuri's Night?

Vocabulary Practice

Choose the word or phrase with the closest meaning to the underlined word or phrase in the following sentences.

1. Yuri Gagarin's parents worked on a Soviet collective farm.
 - a) village
 - b) bank
 - c) place where everyone works together
2. As a young man, Gagarin was training to be a foundry worker.
 - a) one who looks for lost people
 - b) place where metal is melted and shaped
 - c) space
3. In 1957, Russia launched the world's first unmanned spacecraft.
 - a) with no people aboard
 - b) manufactured by machines
 - c) cosmonaut
4. Gagarin worked to prepare others to go on space flights.
 - a) pilots
 - b) trips
 - c) planets
5. Gagarin's ashes were buried in the Kremlin wall beside other Soviet heroes.
 - a) airplane was burned
 - b) remains were placed
 - c) students were trained

Discussion

1. Russia launched both the first unmanned and manned spacecrafts. Why do you think Russia's space programme was so successful at that time?
2. Do you think that countries should spend billions of pounds on space programmes, or do you think that there are other, more important things for governments to spend money on?
3. What characteristics do you think a person needs in order to become an astronaut?
4. Do you think that people will be taking 'space holidays' in the near future?

Answer Key

LESSON DESCRIPTION:

In this lesson, students read about the world's first cosmonaut. They learn some important history about space travel and discuss the future of space holidays. They also learn about an interesting observance called *Yuri's Night*.

LEVEL: Int

TIME: 1.5–2 hours

TAGS: Yuri Gagarin, space travel, space, air, astronaut, cosmonaut, Russia, Russian, hero

Pre-Reading

A. WARM-UP QUESTIONS

- 1, 2, 5. Answers will vary.
3. Russia launched the world's first unmanned spacecraft, *Sputnik*, in 1957.
4. Russia launched the world's first manned spacecraft, *Vostok 1*, in 1961.
6. A space shuttle is a spacecraft which carries people and materials into space and back. It is launched like a rocket, but lands like a plane and can be used again.

B. VOCABULARY PREVIEW

- | | | | | | |
|------|------|------|------|-------|-------|
| 1. f | 3. d | 5. h | 7. j | 9. g | 11. e |
| 2. i | 4. a | 6. l | 8. k | 10. b | 12. c |

Comprehension

A. TRUE OR FALSE?

1. T
2. F – *Sputnik* was the first unmanned spacecraft. *Vostok 1* was the first manned spacecraft.
3. F – Gagarin parachuted into Siberia before landing.
4. T
5. F – Gagarin only made one space flight.

B. ASK & ANSWER

1. Yuri Gagarin became world-famous because he was the first person to orbit the earth in a spacecraft.
2. Gagarin was chosen to be Russia's first cosmonaut after he performed very well in tests on his ability to survive space travel.
3. When Gagarin went into space aboard *Vostok 1*, the spacecraft circled the earth, travelling about 18,000 miles an hour at an altitude of almost 188 miles. The flight lasted 108 minutes.
4. The first manned space flight was controlled by a computer because scientists could not predict how Gagarin would react in the weightlessness of space.
5. The Russian government sent Gagarin and his wife on a world tour so that people everywhere would know about the success of its space programme.
6. After his space flight, Gagarin was made commander of a cosmonaut training programme and worked to prepare others for space travel.
7. Gagarin did not make his second space flight because he died when his jet crashed on March 27, 1968.
8. Yuri's Night is a celebration held every April 12 in many parts of the world that celebrates Gagarin's achievement as well as the first space shuttle launch on April 12, 1981.

Vocabulary Practice

- | | | | | |
|------|------|------|------|------|
| 1. c | 2. b | 3. a | 4. b | 5. b |
|------|------|------|------|------|

Discussion

Answers will vary. Discuss as a class, in groups, or in pairs.